MADHYA PRADESH

UNEASE IN BHOPAL

By Rahul Noronha

In an early morning swoop on May 9, the Madhya Pradesh Anti Terrorism Squad (ATS) arrested 10 people from Bhopal and one from Chhindwara under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The same day in Telangana, five people—two from Bhopal—were picked up in Hyderabad and handed over to the MP ATS. All of them, say the police, have links to the Hizb-ut-Tahrir (HuT), a West Asia-based radical Islamic group that has come under the scanner in India only recently, though it has been banned in 16 countries, including Pakistan.

This is the second time since 2022 that Bhopal is in the news for terrorism-related activities. In March last year, the ATS arrested three Bangladeshi nationals with links to the Jamaat-e-Mujahideen Bangladesh. A few areas in the state have also seen arrests of Popular Front of India (PFI) cadres.

Among those arrested on May 9 is one Yasir Khan, 29, who worked as a gym trainer in Bhopal and is said to be the kingpin of the operation. Per the police, Khan held recruitment drives across the state and had been trying to procure arms. There's also a religious conversion angle—of those held, one person, Mohammed Salim, 35, is a Hindu convert. This has given fodder to the state BJP leadership. Post the arrests, CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan and home minister Narottam Mishra were quick to assert that 'conversions would not be allowed' in the state.

The opposition says the arrests point to growing radicalisation. "Bhopal was never known for harbouring radical Islamic groups. The BJP has caused immense polarisation," said Congress spokesperson Abbas Hafeez. With the assembly election later this year, no surprises if terrorism becomes a poll issue in the coming months. ■

The Gujarat chief minister's office is getting a more digital arsenal to improve governance. After the assembly election win in December 2022, chief minister Bhupendra Patel launched a WhatsApp bot in January and then the Urban Grievance Redressal Monitoring System (UGRMS). The bot allows people to directly connect with the CM. In late April, the CMO also celebrated the 20-year anniversary of the 'Swagat' grievance redressal system where the CM personally interacts with complainants via video conferencing on the fourth Thursday of every month. And at the end of the *chintan shivir* in mid-May, health minister Rushikesh Patel said they were thinking of integrating artificial intelligence (A-I) into administrative functioning.

The UGRMS, meanwhile, is a mechanism to monitor in real time the status of complaints made in eight municipal corporations of the state. It is plugged into a five-year old system called the CM Dashboard that allows Bhupendra's office (CMO) to digitally monitor the implementation of schemes in real time.

After three decades in power in Gujarat, one of the key reasons attributed to the BJP government's success are its schemes and benefits for people. Scheme beneficiaries or *labharthis* are now emerging as a vote bank to reckon with. Effective implementation of government schemes is an evolving challenge. The development of the CM Dashboard was initiated in 2018, with help from the central National Informatics Centre (NIC). The dashboard is a visual insight of more than 4,500 indicators of 20 sectors of all the state government departments consolidated under a single umbrella. The dashboard also integrates all the key stakeholders, like the secretaries, HoDs, collectors, DDOs (district development officers) and SPs (police superintendents) on a single platform. The dashboard accesses data through more than 50,000 data points and 187 e-governance applications of 26 departments. All flagship schemes of the Centre and state government are monitored.

"It was a mammoth task to monitor government schemes and performance on real-time basis," a senior officer in the CMO explains. "In May 2018, we started with 41 nodal and sub-nodal officers. Progressively, the CM Dashboard covered the entire administration of 33 districts, 248 talukas and 18,000-plus villages." This involves 401 nodal and sub-nodal officers monitoring over 125 schemes on a regular basis. More than 80 per cent of the data is received through automated web services.

THE CM'S DASHBOARD HELPS IN DIGITAL MONITORING OF GOVERNMENT SCHEMES' IMPLEMENTATION IN REAL TIME

The dashboard is linked with 750 web services of all departments through various APIs (application programming interfaces). Given that it deals with high-security information, it has been set up at the CM's residence. Real-time feedback is obtained by the dashboard team every day by random calling scheme beneficiaries. So far, over 900,000 calls have been made through this '*jan samvad*' in the past five years. This data is